

Globetrotting Online

And no, by this we don't mean some new way of virtual travel. What we're telling you is how to plan your entire trip—business or pleasure—online, from the comfort of your chair!

Aditya Kuber

A holiday is a time to relax, but often, you get so hassled ensuring everything goes smoothly that you forget to relax! Is there any way to avoid making ten trips to ten agents trying to get the best deal? Is there an easier way to plan your own trip?

The answer is yes. Online.

Over the last few years, security for online payments has improved considerably. With almost all online payments going through SSL (Secure Sockets Layers) servers, there's little need to worry. But is there a one-stop solution to planning a trip online? Read on...

The Information Desk

Before you can plan your trip, it's important to know where exactly you want to go. All right, you've decided it's going to be Australia, but you cannot see the whole of Australia in ten days. You can't even see the whole of Mumbai in that much time! So educate yourself. How?

Travel agency Web sites are often a good resource to know more about your destination. As a matter of fact, these can be a better source of information than other resources, Web or print. For one, these are more focused on your destination, and can provide a good indicator of what to expect. This can be especially helpful as a starting point if you are taking a package tour, and can also be a point of comparison.

In addition to knowing more about the destination, there are a couple of links (found on most travel sites) you must click on: 'Details' and 'Itinerary'.

'Details' usually spells out all that's 'Included' and all that's not in your package (in the case of a package tour). 'Itinerary' tells you exactly how much time you would have to yourself and how many places you are going to visit and when.

In the case of airline ticket booking, the link called 'Details' or 'Terms and Conditions' is the most important. Airlines allow you to book a one-way, round trip or a multi-city trip online. The cancellation rules and regulations as well as some booking guidelines are very important.

For instance, Jet Airways does not allow online booking of tickets for infants. Also, when booking domestic travel tickets on Jet Airways, foreign nationals

have to pay in US dollars. You have to read the fine-print points before proceeding with a final booking.



Imaging Akhilesh Prasad